India, Ceylon (Sri Lanka) and Singapore.[60] For both Krishnamachari and Panikkar the dominant country in the grouping would be India.[61]

Several other Indian strategists too saw Independence as the opportunity for India to break out of its isolation and play a role on the world stage. One of them, P.N. Kirpal, wrote in 1945, 'Three great highways connect her [India] with the rest of the world. From Calcutta towards the South and South-East, the sea routes reach Australia and New Zealand, the islands and countries of South- East Pacific and the great powers of China and Japan in the Far East. From Bombay and Karachi here are old and easy sea routes to the Middle East, Africa and Europe. From Delhi to the passes of the North-West our railway system reaches the most ancient of the world's highways of commerce and culture, the land route from India to Europe.'[62] According to K.N.V. Sastri, India was to become not only a first-rate military power but also a country that achieves 'moral greatness and spiritual height'.[63]

These views of several early Indian strategic thinkers and policy planners reflected the British outlook about India's neighbourhood, national interest and sphere of influence, albeit with an Indian twist. According to British strategists the British Indian Empire was at its core, a 'kernel' comprising the British Indian provinces and princely states. The next layer were states like Bhutan and Nepal over whom the Raj exercised control of their defence and security policies. A further layer was that of a ring of buffer states or territories like Afghanistan, Tibet and Persia – and even Xinjiang – that the British hoped would remain neutral in any conflict. In this world view, India's area of interest stretched from the Gulf on the one hand to Indo-China on the other.[64]



To those trying to weave in ancient Indian philosophy with British strategic thought, there was a Kautilyan quality to the foreign policy of India under British colonial rule. As Caroe explained: 'A large idea lay behind all